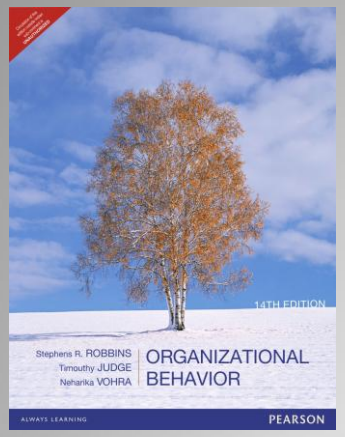

Chapter 10

Robbins, Judge, and Vohra

Organizational Behavior

14th Edition

Understanding Work Teams

Kelli J. Schutte
William Jewell College

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Chapter Learning Objectives

- **After studying this chapter, you should be able to:**
  - Analyze the growing popularity of teams in organizations.
  - Contrast groups and teams.
  - Compare and contrast four types of teams.
  - Identify the characteristics of effective teams.
  - Show how organizations can create team players.
  - Decide when to use individuals instead of teams.
  - Show how our understanding of teams differs in a global context.

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Why Have Teams Become So Popular?

- Great way to use employee talents
- Teams are more flexible and responsive to changes in the environment
- Can quickly assemble, deploy, refocus, and disband
- Facilitate employee involvement
- Increase employee participation in decision making
- Democratize an organization and increase motivation

Note: Teams are not ALWAYS effective

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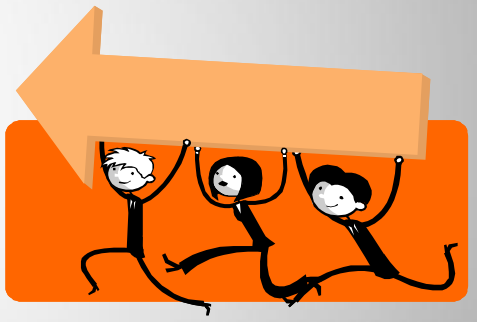
Differences between Groups and Teams

- Work Group
  - A group that interacts primarily to share information and to make decisions to help each group member perform within his or her area of responsibility
  - No joint effort required



- Work Team
  - Generates positive synergy through coordinated effort. The individual efforts result in a performance that is greater than the sum of the individual inputs

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Comparing Work Groups and Work Teams

Work groups		Work teams
Share information	Goal	Collective performance
Neutral (sometimes negative)	Synergy	Positive
Individual	Accountability	Individual and mutual
Random and varied	Skills	Complementary

EXHIBIT 10-1

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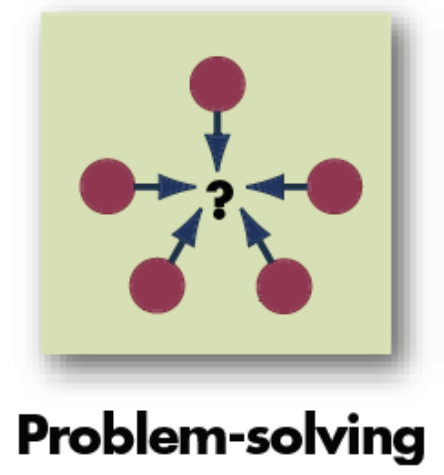
Types of Teams

- Problem-Solving Teams
  - Groups of 5 to 12 employees from the same department who meet for a few hours each week to discuss ways of improving quality, efficiency, and the work environment



- Self-Managed Work Teams
  - Groups of 10 to 15 people who take on the responsibilities of their former supervisors

See E X H I B I T 10-2

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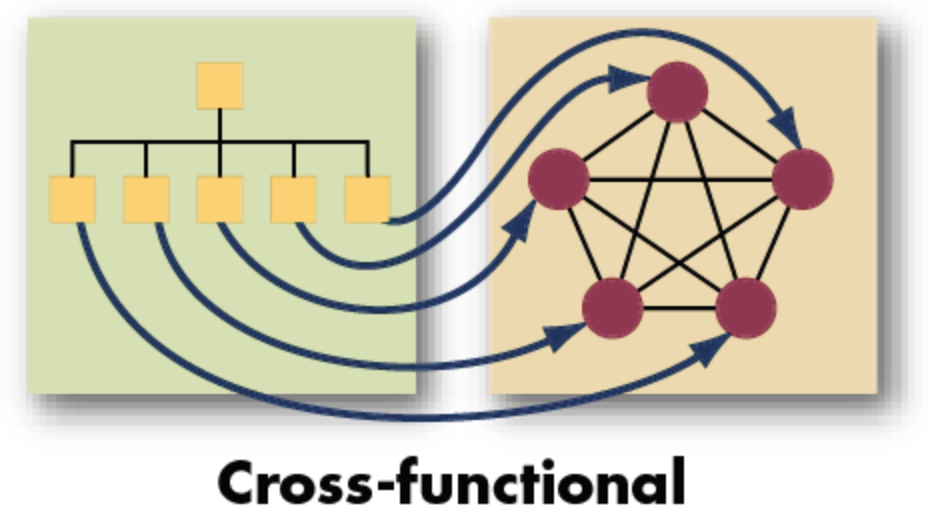
Types of Teams (Continued)

- Cross-Functional Teams
  - Employees from about the same hierarchical level, but from different work areas, who come together to accomplish a task
  - Very common
  - Task forces
  - Committees



See E X H I B I T 10-2

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Types of Teams (Continued)

Virtual Teams

- Teams that use computer technology to tie together physically dispersed members in order to achieve a common goal

- **Characteristics**
  - Limited socializing
  - The ability to overcome time and space constraints
- **To be effective, needs:**
  - Trust among members
  - Close monitoring
  - To be publicized

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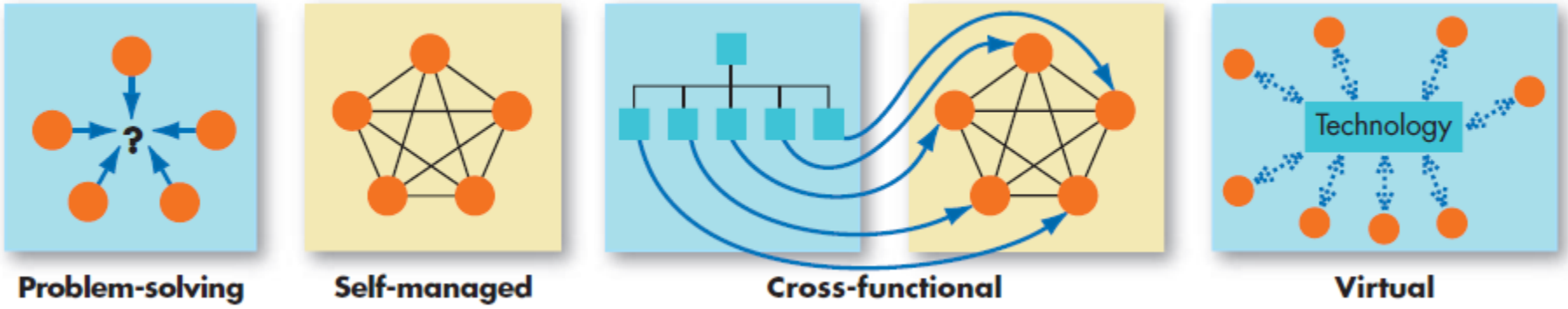

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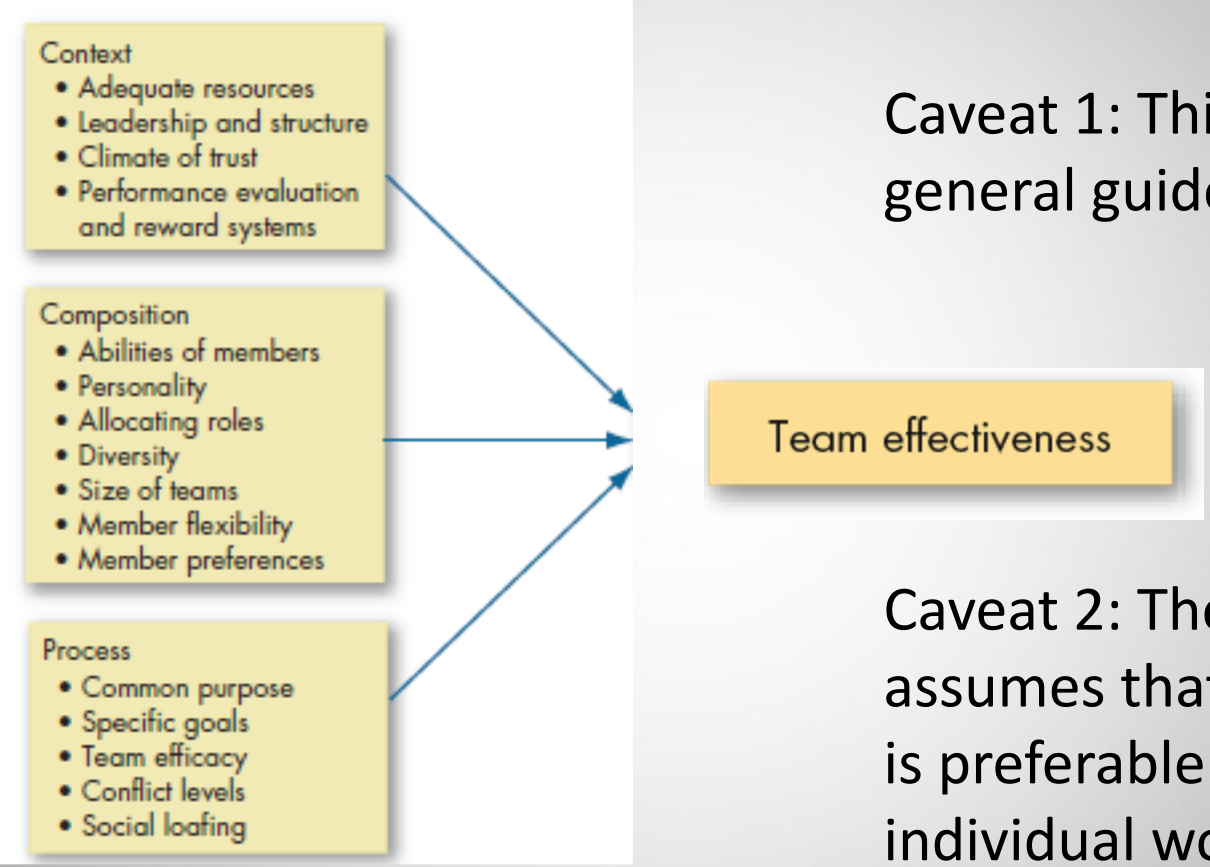
A Team-Effectiveness Model



Caveat 1: This is a general guide only.

Caveat 2: The model assumes that teamwork is preferable to individual work.

EXHIBIT 10-3

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Key Components of Effective Teams

- **Context**
- **Composition**
- **Process Variables**

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Creating Effective Teams: Context

- **Adequate Resources**
  - Need the tools to complete the job
- **Effective Leadership and Structure**
  - Agreeing to the specifics of work and how the team fits together to integrate individual skills
  - Even "self-managed" teams need leaders
  - Leadership especially important in multi-team systems
- **Climate of Trust**
  - Members must trust each other and the leader
- **Performance and Rewards Systems that Reflect Team Contributions**
  - Cannot just be based on individual effort

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Creating Effective Teams: Composition

- **Abilities of Members**
  - Need technical expertise, problem-solving, decision-making, and good interpersonal skills
- **Personality of Members**
  - Conscientiousness, openness to experience, and agreeableness all relate to team performance
- **Allocating Roles and Diversity**
  - Many necessary roles must be filled
  - Diversity can often lead to lower performance
- **Size of Team**
  - The smaller the better: 5 to 9 is optimal
- **Members' Preference for Teamwork**
  - Do the members want to be on teams?

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Key Roles Of Teams

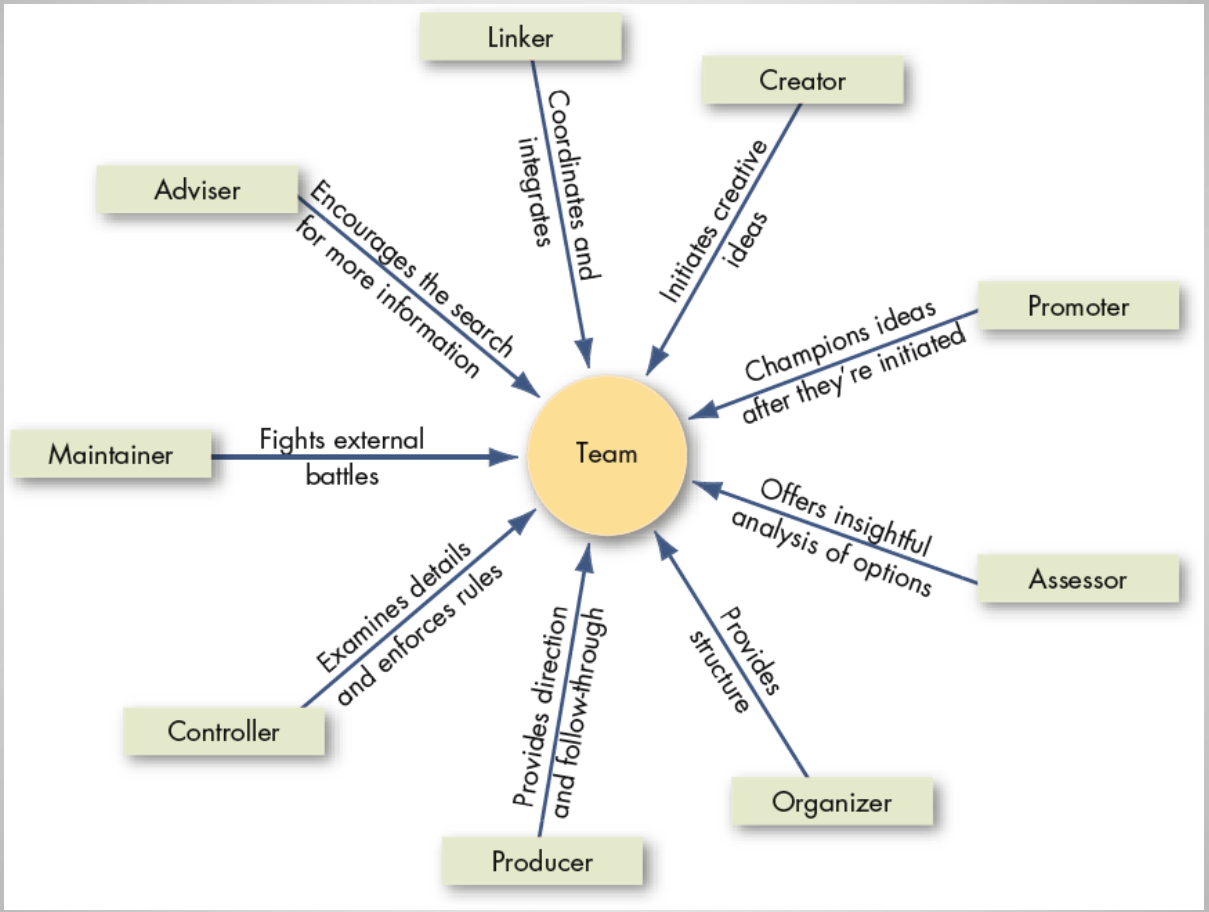

EXHIBIT 10-4

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Creating Effective Teams: Team Processes

- **Commitment to a Common Purpose**
  - Create a common purpose that provides direction
  - Have *reflexivity*: willing to adjust plan if necessary
- **Establishment of Specific Team Goals**
  - Must be specific, measurable, realistic, and challenging
- **Team Efficacy**
  - Team believes in its ability to succeed
- **Mental Models**
  - Have an accurate and common mental map of how the work gets done
- **A Managed Level of Conflict**
  - Task conflicts are helpful; interpersonal conflicts are not
- **Minimized Social Loafing**
  - Team holds itself accountable both individually and as a team

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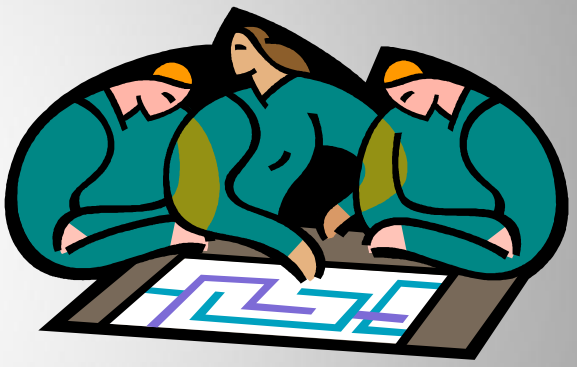
Turning Individuals into Team Players

- **Selection**
  - Make team skills one of the interpersonal skills in the hiring process.
- **Training**
  - Individualistic people can learn



- **Rewards**
  - Rework the reward system to encourage cooperative efforts rather than competitive (individual) ones
  - Continue to recognize individual contributions while still emphasizing the importance of teamwork

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Beware! Teams Aren't Always the Answer

Teams take more time and resources than does individual work.

- **Three tests to see if a team fits the situation:**

1. Is the work complex and is there a need for different perspectives – will it be better with the insights of more than one person?
2. Does the work create a common purpose or set of goals for the group that is larger than the aggregate of the goals for individuals?
3. Are members of the group involved in interdependent tasks?

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Global Implications

- **Extent of Teamwork**
  - Although work teams are pervasive in India, some evidence suggests that most Indians are individual players rather than team players
- **Self-Managed Teams**
  - Do not work well in countries with low tolerance for ambiguity and uncertainty and a high power distance
- **Team Cultural Diversity and Team Performance**
  - Diversity caused by national differences interferes with team efficiency, at least in the short run
  - After about three months, the differences between diverse and non-diverse team performance disappear

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Summary and Managerial Implications

- **Effective teams have common characteristics:**
  - Adequate resources
  - Effective leadership
  - A climate of trust
  - Appropriate reward and evaluation systems
  - Composed of members with correct skills and roles
  - Are smaller
  - Do work that provides freedom, autonomy, and the chance to contribute
  - The tasks are whole and significant
  - Has members who believe in the team's capabilities
- *Managers should modify the environment and select team-oriented individuals to increase the chance of developing effective teams.*

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